HAMASPIK LEOVDEI HASHEM

Generosity & Calmness: HaMaspik LeOvdei HaShem, Chapters 5 - 6

Given Monday 23 March 2026 · HaMaspik LeOvdei HaShem

Sefer: HaMaspik L'Ovdei Hashem (Kifayat al-Abidin) — Rabbi Avraham ben HaRambam
Chapters: End of Perek 5 (נדיבות — Generosity) & Beginning of Perek 6 (אריכות אפים — Slow to Anger / Calmness) **Edition:** Feldheim

---

Recap: Chapters 1–5

- **Chapter 1:** Two paths — the Tzaddik (fulfills everything required) and the Chasid (goes beyond). The sefer focuses on the Chasid's path.
- **Chapter 2:** All middot are interrelated — working on one affects others.
- **Chapter 3:** Purity of motive — four levels, from serving for social pressure (lowest) to serving because Hashem commanded (highest).
- **Chapter 4:** Rachamanut (compassion) — first of the 13 Attributes of Mercy. Very important, but sometimes cruelty is necessary. When in doubt → choose mercy.
- **Chapter 5 (first part):** Nedivut (generosity) — giving when there's no obligation. Four kinds: money, influence, intellect, faith. Avraham Avinu modeled all four.

Chapter 5 (Conclusion): The Knock-On Effects of Generosity

Generosity Trains Satisfaction and Trust in Hashem

ומנדיבון הנפלא של אברהם אבינו... למדים אנחנו על גדולת טבעו הנדיב

- From Avraham's generosity we learn about his generous nature
- But also: **a byproduct of generosity** = being satisfied with what you have, not putting too much emphasis on transient things

Avraham's example:

- Torah tells us: אברם כבד מאד במקנה בכסף ובזהב — very wealthy
- Yet after winning the war against the kings:

הרימותי ידי אל ה' אל עליון... אם מחוט ועד שרוך נעל... ולא תאמר אני העשרתי את אברם

- "I don't want anything. I don't need your money."
- Despite being wealthy → not greedy, not constantly wanting more
- Generosity trains this: when you give freely, you learn to be content

Each Kind of Generosity Has a Specific Knock-On Effect

Rabbi Avraham goes through all four:

1. Generosity with Money → Trust in Hashem (Bitachon)

- The fact you're willing to give ma'aser, tzedakah, 10–20% → shows trust that Hashem will provide
- Also reminds us: don't focus on transient things — money comes and goes
- **The opposite (kamtzanut with money):** Causes lack of trust in Hashem and over-focus on material things

2. Generosity with Influence → Trust Hashem Will Maintain Your Power

- Sharing your connections and influence → shows trust that your ability won't diminish
- You won't become less powerful by helping others
- **Rabbi Sacks' principle:** Power = zero-sum game. Influence = the opposite — the more you share, the more you have.
- **The opposite:** Hoarding influence → shows lack of trust, belief that everything is in human hands alone

3. Generosity with Intellect → Belief That Wisdom Grows by Sharing

- Teaching others → shows you trust your wisdom won't diminish

הרבה חכמה למדתי מחברי יותר מרבותי ומתלמידי יותר מכולם

- "I learned much from my colleagues, more from my teachers, but the most from my students"
- True wisdom (חכמה נכונה) = wisdom you can teach and express to others
- Shlomo HaMelech: חכמות בחוץ תרנה — true wisdom sings in the streets, proclaims itself publicly
- **The Brisker Rav:** "If you can't explain it to your chavruta, you don't understand it"
- **The opposite:** Hoarding knowledge → shows you don't truly value it and don't trust it will endure

4. Generosity with Faith → Shows You Love Your Beliefs

- If you truly love something → you want to share it
- If you truly believe → you want others to experience it too
- Dovid HaMelech: לכו בנים שמעו לי יראת ה' אלמדכם — "Come, children, I will teach you the fear of Hashem"
- **The opposite:** Sitting in your corner, becoming uber-religious but not sharing → shows lack of excitement about your faith, lack of genuine love for it

The Rambam in Hilchot Tzedakah (Chapter 10)

לעולם אין אדם מעני מן הצדקה ואין דבר רע ולא היזק נגלל בשביל הצדקה

- You will **never** lose out from charity
- No harm or damage ever comes from generosity

the result of charity is peace — והיה מעשה הצדקה שלום

Chapter 6: אריכות אפים — Slow to Anger / Calmness (Part 1)

Definition

אריכות אפים היא ביטוי להעדר החמה והכעס כמעט כליל

- Arichut Apayim = an **almost** complete absence of anger
- He says "almost" — because sometimes anger is necessary (he'll address this later)
- One of the 13 Attributes of Mercy: אל רחום וחנון **ארך אפים**

Nature vs. Training

- Some people have a **natural tendency** toward calmness — balanced temperament, serene character → easier for them to acquire this trait
- Others have a **natural tendency** toward hot-temperedness — חמוצי מזג, easily angered → much harder for them
- In their science/medicine: believed to depend on the balance of the four humors in the body
- **Either way → training is essential**
- If you're naturally prone to anger → you need more training, but that's life
- Hashem created us with inequalities — some find it harder than others

Why We Can Never Judge Others

אל תדין את חברך עד שתגיע למקומו — Don't judge your fellow until you reach his place (Pirkei Avot)

- A person who gets angry once may be worse than someone who gets angry five times
- The five-times person may have stopped himself 45 other times — because it's much harder for him
- The once-angry person may find it easy — so why did he even get angry that one time?
- Only Hashem can truly judge character and temperament

The Core Principle: Intellect Must Trump Emotion

אריכות האפיים המשובחת היא שליטת כוח השכל על כוח היצר

- The essence of calmness = **intellect in control over emotion**
- **Melech (King) = מוח = מלך (brain) → לב (heart) → כבד (action)** (Rav Moshe Shapiro)
- A person who's truly in control: brain directs heart directs action
- Not the reverse — when emotions direct the brain, mistakes follow

Anger = Loss of Intellect

אם חכם הוא חכמתו מסתלקת ממנו

- The Gemara says: even the greatest chacham, when angry, loses his wisdom
- This is NOT a supernatural punishment — it's a **natural consequence**
- When emotion takes full control → intellect is simply no longer functioning
- You can't reason with an angry person, just like you can't reason with a drunk person

Two Important Qualifications

1. Calmness ≠ Apathy

ולא מתוך קרירות מזג בעלמא או רפיון היצרים או מורך הלב

- Being calm doesn't mean being weak, submissive, or apathetic
- It doesn't mean everyone runs over you
- Sometimes you NEED to show displeasure, be firm, be stern

2. Consequences Are Important — But Not from Anger

מי שמעניש כפי חובתו לא מתוך רתחה ולא מתוך התרגשות הרי הוא ממדרגת חסידות גדולה קרוב לנבואה

- A person who punishes when necessary — not from anger, not from emotion — is at an extremely high level of piety, close to prophecy
- This is NOT revenge (nekama) — it's called עונש צדק (just consequences)
- **The Rambam in Hilchot De'ot:** If you need to educate/reprimand → show yourself as angry (pretend), but be fully in control internally. Your intellect remains in charge — you're acting angry, not being angry.

Anger Causes Revenge and Harboring

הכעס המסית לנקמה... ומוציא משטמה בנפש פנימה

- Anger causes two things:
- **Nekama (revenge)** — if you have power → you act on it immediately
- **Netira (harboring)** — if you lack power → it simmers inside, bubbling, festering
- The Torah juxtaposes them: לא תקום ולא תטור — don't take revenge AND don't harbor
- Both are destructive
- Harboring leaves an imprint within a person — studies show links between living with anger/resentment and health problems (including cancer)

Anger and Drunkenness

הכעס מעביר את האדם מדעתו ממש כשיכור

- The Chachamim compared anger to drunkenness:

לא תרתח ולא תחטא, לא תרוה ולא תחטא

- "Don't get angry and you won't sin; don't get drunk and you won't sin"
- The parallel: both cause complete loss of intellect
- An angry person = a drunk person: can't rationalize, can't reason with them
- Look at an angry person — they look crazy, like they've lost control

Anger and Arrogance Go Hand-in-Hand

דרך הסבלנות ודרך הענווה שותפות הן כשם שדרכי הכעס והגאווה שותפות הן

Paired Together	Paired Together
Patience + Humility	Anger + Arrogance

- What causes anger? Often arrogance: "I'm going to show you! You can't do this to ME! You've belittled ME!"
- What causes patience? Humility: "It's not about me"

- The Gemara: לעולם יהא אדם ענוותן כהלל ואל יהא קפדן כשמאי — Be humble like Hillel, don't be strict like Shammai
- What does humility have to do with strictness? Because they're linked — if you're humble, you won't be quick to anger

Levels of Anger — Where Do You Fall?

אדם בעל מזג ממוצע אינו רוגז על קלות ואינו עומד בחמורות

- **Normal person:** Gets angry at big things, doesn't get angry at small things
- Not yet called "patient" — but not called "angry" either
- Most of us fall here
- **Closer to angry:** Gets angry at small things too → he's on the wrong side
- **Closer to calm:** Doesn't get angry even at serious provocations → he's on the right path
- Many levels and variations in between

Mesilat Yesharim (Ramchal, end of Chapter 11): Goes through different levels of anger — from the highest level (like serving avodah zarah, would destroy the world if he could) down through various gradations.

What Does "Calmness" Actually Mean?

כעס המגונה הוא אפילו כשכועס אדם על מה שראוי לכעוס עליו

- Bad anger isn't just getting angry for no reason — only fools do that
- **Bad anger = getting angry even when it's REASONABLE to be angry**
- **True calmness = not getting angry even when you have every right to be**

The Hillel story (Gemara Shabbat):

- Two people made a bet: can you get Hillel angry?
- One went to Hillel on Erev Shabbat while he was in the bathhouse
- Asked ridiculous questions: "Why are Babylonians' heads round?" etc.
- Hillel had every right to be angry — but he wasn't. He answered calmly.
- The man lost his bet
- This is the model of true calmness

Training for Calmness — Two Methods

Method 1: Habit (Mussar / Training)

שירגיל האדם את נפשו לאריכות אפיים בדברים מרגיזים

Practical steps:

a) When about to get angry → let intellect rein:

ולא ימהר חימה כמו שציווה שלמה אל תבהל ברוחך לכעוס

- Don't rush to anger — slow down
- Count to ten, take a breath — whatever method works
- This is already discussed in Rabbi Avraham's time — "anger management" is not modern

b) Remember the consequences of past anger:

יזכור את התפרצות רוגזו בימי חייו ואשר גרם לו

- Think about times you DID get angry
- What were the consequences?
- Broken relationships — some can never be fixed
- Words that left the mouth that can never be returned

Like arrows: once they leave, you can't take them back — כחצי גיבור שנונים

- Marriages destroyed by a single comment
- Friendships ended by a moment of rage
- Think about this BEFORE you get angry next time

c) Remember: whatever gain you think anger will bring → you'll lose in the end:

עתיד שכרו לצאת בהפסד ייסורים

- "I'll teach this person a lesson!" → In the short term you feel vindicated
- In the long term → you lose. Always.
- Shlomo: איש חמה יגרה מדון וארך אפים ישקיט ריב — Angry people are always fighting; calm people have peace

d) The fundamental realization:

- You cannot change other people — only yourself
- The older you get, the more you realize this
- Trying to "teach someone a lesson" through anger almost never works
- Far easier to change how YOU react than to change others

e) The 40-day principle:

- One of the Chasidic masters: train something for 40 days → it becomes part of your character
- The Omer period beginning in a week → ideal time to start working on this
- Even if we can't fully change → just pausing to think before getting angry = progress

Method 2: Torah — Two Sub-Categories

שניים הם סוגי התקשרות על ידי התורה לאריכות אפיים

a) Stories in Torah and Nevi'im — examples of anger and its consequences, and calmness and its rewards (covered in this shiur — see below)

b) Mitzvot of the Torah — specific commandments designed to train patience and prevent anger (to be covered next shiur)

Negative Examples from Torah: Anger and Its Consequences

1. Kayin and Hevel

- Kayin got angry → killed his brother

"My sin is too great" — גדול עוני מנשוא

- Punished with exile; his descendants also punished (Tuval Kayin killed by Lemech's accident)

- Root cause: **anger and jealousy**

2. Eisav and Yaakov

- Eisav's hatred → decided to kill Yaakov
  "When my father dies, I'll kill Yaakov" — ויאמר עשו בלבו יקרבו ימי אבל אבי ואהרגה את יעקב אחי
- Rivka said: wait עד אשר תשוב חמת אחיך — until your brother's anger cools down
- Years later (beginning of Vayishlach) → Yaakov still worried about Eisav's anger
  I'll calm his face" (Onkelos: "I'll calm his anger")" — אכפרה פניו
- **Anger's long reach:** decades of broken brotherhood

3. The Brothers and Yosef

- Their hatred → decided to kill him
- Root cause: anger over his dreams
- Onkelos: וימררוהו ורבו — they were bitter and wanted revenge
- No doubt they regretted when they saw Yaakov's devastation
- But: **what's done is done** — regret didn't help
- Consequences: they ended up going down to Egypt → slavery
- Yaakov's words about Shimon and Levi: ארור אפם כי עז — "Cursed is their anger, for it is fierce"

4. Moshe at Mei Merivah

- The Rambam's understanding (followed by Rabbi Avraham): the sin was NOT hitting the rock
- The sin was **getting angry** — when he called Bnei Yisrael שמעו נא המורים — "Listen, you rebellious ones!"
- He lost control of his emotions (on his level, as it were)
- **Consequence:** Could not enter Eretz Yisrael
- There are 20+ explanations of Moshe's sin — but the Rambam's: it was the anger

5. Shaul and the Kohanim of Nov

- Shaul thought the Kohanim in Nov were supporting his enemies
- Out of anger → destroyed Nov, the city of Kohanim
- Despite being God's chosen king

6. David and Naval

- Naval insulted David → David was about to kill him out of anger
- Avigayil stopped him: "This will be bad for you"
- David responded: ברוכה את אשר כליתיני היום הזה מבוא בדמים — "Blessed are you for stopping me from bloodshed"
- He recognized his anger almost led to a terrible sin

7. David and Mephibosheth

- Ziva told David that Mephibosheth was against him (a lie)
- David accepted it out of anger → didn't accept Mephibosheth's excuse later
- Punished David: יצאה בת קול — "Rechav'am and Yerav'am will divide the kingdom"
- The division of the kingdom traced back to this moment of anger

8. Asa King of Yehuda

- Despite being a righteous king → got angry with the prophet Hanani

  ויכעס אסא אל הרואה — he was angry at the seer
- Imprisoned him → led to bloodshed

9. Yoash King of Yehuda

- Got angry → killed Zechariah ben Yehoyada the Kohen
- Despite Yehoyada having been kind to Yoash
- Anger caused him to forget all the chesed done for him

The Chachamim's Statement: Anger = Avodah Zarah

הקורע בגדיו בחמתו ומפזר מעותיו בחמתו יהיה בעיניך כעובד עבודה זרה

- Tearing clothes in anger, throwing things around in anger = **like serving avodah zarah**
- Today the yetzer tells you: do this. Tomorrow: go serve avodah zarah.
- And: לא יהיה בך אל זר — "You shall not have a foreign god within you"
- What foreign god is within you? → זה יצר הרע — the yetzer hara
- The specific meaning: that force of emotion where you lose all intellectual control = the "foreign god" within

---

Key Takeaways

1. **Generosity has knock-on effects:** Generosity with money → bitachon. With influence → trust Hashem maintains your power. With intellect → wisdom grows by sharing. With faith → shows you truly love it.
2. **Calmness = intellect in control over emotion.** Not apathy, not weakness.
3. **Anger = loss of intellect** — like drunkenness. The Gemara's "wisdom departs" is a natural consequence, not a punishment.
4. **Anger and arrogance go hand-in-hand.** Patience and humility go hand-in-hand.
5. **True calmness** = not getting angry even when you have every right to be (the Hillel model).
6. **Consequences are important** — but deliver them calmly, with intellect in control. That's close to prophecy.
7. **You can't change other people** — only yourself. Anger aimed at "teaching someone a lesson" almost never works.
8. **Training Method 1 (Habit):** Remember past consequences, slow down, let intellect rein.
9. **Training Method 2 (Torah):** Learn from the stories — every major act of destruction in Tanakh traces back to anger.
10. **Anger = like avodah zarah** — the "foreign god within you" is the yetzer hara of uncontrolled emotion.

Preview: Next Shiur (After Pesach)

- Positive examples from Torah — people who were calm and gained from it
- Mitzvot of the Torah designed to train patience
- When calmness is NOT appropriate

- What to do when in doubt
- The concept of "anger" attributed to God

Chag Pesach Kasher v'Sameach

Watch or listen to this shiur: youtu.be/8Q7iKFwHRaw · More shiurim: rabbikada.com